

More Time & Higher Energy

Myth Busting

- We are limited to 2-3 high potential hours per day. Many people suffer from hubris by believing that their high potential hours are infinite. All our energy levels fluctuate so we need to match tasks as best we can to the energy levels most suitable to them e.g. easier admin tasks can be completed during lower potential hours.
- Saying “yes” all the time is a positive. In actual fact it is not. By learning to say “no” strategically we can protect our calendars and energy levels to get our most important work done. It can also have the surprising knock on benefit that people start to hold us in higher regard as saying no in the right way can exchange popularity for respect.
- There is a false belief that motivation is necessary for action and is the fuel to overcome procrastination. The truth here is we need to teach ourselves to do things even when we are not motivated and then often motivation will follow after the initial forced action.

Useful Thought Experiments

- Am I matching my high potential hours to my high focused tasks? An example would be that you need to work on a really important client slide deck yet you commit your high potential hours (let's say 10.00-12.00) to catching up with some colleagues. Consider blocking these hours off in your calendar to remind you not to make commitments so easily during them.
- Could I keep my energy levels topped up better throughout the day? Am I leveraging exercise, breaks from the desk, healthy food and napping as much as I could? Remember that Google, Zappos and Nike aren't embracing napping facilities for employees out of the good of their hearts, it's because they recognise a productivity return. Research shows that it can increase focus and ideally takes place 6-7.5 hours after waking.
- Am I procrastinating on this issue because it's scaring me, seems boring to me or it's unclear to me? Once you get clear about why you are avoiding it, this can help you to build the willpower to act on the tasks and ultimately overcome procrastination while relieving stress. An example would be that you realise you're avoiding it because you're afraid of failing so you imagine outsourcing the task to a friend, telling them A-Z what needs to be done. You've created psychological distance by imagining outsourcing it and have actually broke through procrastination by completing your to-do list.

Protecting Your Calendar?

- If you're committing too easily to events and meetings, could you start using a stock phrase like, “let me check my calendar and get back to you”. This will save you from time wasting commitments which you will later regret.
- Are you ensuring that you don't attend/organise time wasting meetings? Avoid this plight with clear goals, agendas and flexibility to let pressed speakers deliver their parts and leave.

